Karl Zettl

Co-Founder & CEO, Iknaio Cryptoasset Analytics GmbH
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Engineer and CEO of Iknaio, with more than 15 years in business development, international sales, and product management in payments, banking technology, and security. Co-founded Iknaio in 2021 and has since built its customer network across law enforcement, regulators, and financial institutions in the DACH region, and leads the company's European expansion. Before Iknaio, held sales and business-development leadership roles at smart-card and semiconductor companies (Austria Card, exceet Card, Infineon), responsible for banking customers in up to twelve European countries. Trained as an engineer in telematics at Graz University of Technology, with research stays at the German Aerospace Center (DLR) and Carnegie Mellon University.

Key Achievements

- **Building Iknaio** – As co-founder and managing director since 2021, runs the company day to day and turned the open-source GraphSense research platform into commercial investigation products for law enforcement, regulators, and financial institutions; Iknaio received the **Houska Prize 2024** (2nd place), Austria's premier award for innovative IT solutions.
- **International sales in regulated markets** – Regional Sales Director at Austria Card for ten Central and Eastern European countries; won contracts with two international bank groups and set up card personalisation centres in Poland and Romania.
- **Business development and turnaround** – Head of Business Development at exceet Card Austria for twelve European markets; led the operational and financial restructuring of the German subsidiary and introduced sales processes for a new product line.
- **Payment standards and product strategy** – Technical Marketing Manager Payment at Infineon; developed the payment product roadmap and took part in standardisation bodies such as EMVCo.
- **Voice of the industry** – Represents Iknaio at law-enforcement and policy events, including the CINTIA 2024 conference in Warsaw and the CEO panel on data-exchange standards at the Digital Innovation Summit Bucharest 2025.
- **Engineering background** – Dipl.-Ing. in Telematics; research on free-space optical communication at DLR and TU Graz and on computer vision at Carnegie Mellon University, with seven peer-reviewed publications.

Professional Experience

2021 – Present	**Co-Founder & CEO (Managing Director)**, *Iknaio Cryptoasset Analytics GmbH, Vienna*. Company building, sales, and business development for cryptoasset analytics products serving law enforcement, regulators, and financial institutions.
2018 – Present	**CEO & Consultant**, *Peak Software Solutions GmbH, Hartberg*. Consulting on product innovation, business development, and sales for banks, including a German market-entry strategy for an Austrian bank; software development.
2016 – 2018	**Head of Business Development**, *exceet Card Austria GmbH, Vienna*. New products, sales and marketing strategy, and partnerships for banking smart cards in twelve European countries.
2012 – 2015	**Regional Sales Director**, *Austria Card GmbH, Vienna*. Pricing, sales strategy, and sales team for banking cards in ten CEE countries.

2011 – 2012	**Technical Marketing Manager Payment**, *Infineon Technologies AG, Neubiberg (Germany)*. Market trends and product roadmap for banking and payment chips; EMVCo standardisation.
2007 – 2010	**Project Manager → Key Account Manager**, *Austria Card GmbH, Vienna*. Bank- and credit-card projects in the UK, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, and Turkey; key accounts in Austria, Germany, Norway, and Sweden.
2005 – 2007	**Research positions**, *TU Graz, Institute of Broadband Communications (Study Assistant); Carnegie Mellon University, Robotics Institute (Visiting Scholar); German Aerospace Center DLR (Software Developer, Master's thesis)*.

Education

2006	**Dipl.-Ing. in Telematics**, *Graz University of Technology*. Telecommunication and mobile computing; computer vision and graphics.
2004	**BSc in Telematics**, *Graz University of Technology*.

Selected Talks & Events

2025	**Panel "Towards Data Exchange Standards and Interoperability – CEO Level Discussions"**, *Digital Innovation Summit Bucharest*.
2025	**10 Years of the Central Office for Cybercrime Bavaria (ZCB)**, *Bamberg*. Representing Iknaio.
2024	**Blockchain analysis against financial crime**, *CINTIA 2024 Analytical Conference, Polish Platform for Homeland Security, Warsaw*.

Languages

German (native), English (excellent).

Selected Publications

1. **Zettl, K.**, Sheikh Muhammad, S., Chlestil, C., Leitgeb, E., Friedl, A., Schmitt, N. P., & Rehm, W. (2007). High bit rate optical wireless systems for swarm unmanned aerial vehicles: A feasibility study. *Mediterranean Journal of Computers and Networks*.
2. Leitgeb, E., **Zettl, K.**, Sheikh Muhammad, S., Schmitt, N., & Rehm, W. (2007). Investigation in free space optical communication links between unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs). In *9th International Conference on Transparent Optical Networks (ICTON)*. IEEE.